

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 1022

By McNally

A RESOLUTION providing for the installation of a bust in the State Capitol to honor Anne M. Davis, the founding mother of Great Smoky Mountains National Park.

WHEREAS, Anne M. Davis is universally recognized as the founding mother of Great Smoky Mountains National Park (GSMNP); this remarkable lady not only initiated the idea for the park, she helped generate essential public support for the project and, as a State legislator, sponsored and passed legislation for the purchase of land to establish the park; and

WHEREAS, Ann May grew up in society in Louisville, Kentucky, where she was active in philanthropic and church work, and graduated from Bryn Mawr College; in 1902, she married industrialist Willis Perkins "W.P." Davis; and

WHEREAS, in 1915, the Davises relocated to Knoxville, where Mr. Davis served as general manager of Knoxville Iron Works Company, and the couple soon became active in community affairs; and

WHEREAS, described as "a force of nature" and "a rebel," Anne M. Davis first became involved in conservation and environmental issues through her membership in the Knoxville Garden Club; and

WHEREAS, the Davises frequently visited the Smokies, and in addition to enjoying the beauty of the mountains, they recognized the potential of the Smokies in promoting tourism and business for nearby communities, including Knoxville; and

WHEREAS, Mr. and Mrs. Davis promoted the idea of a Smoky Mountains national park within the Knoxville business community as an engine for economic growth, and they were active in founding the Great Smoky Mountains Conservation Association to achieve that purpose; and

WHEREAS, through the organization, Mr. and Mrs. Davis presented a proposal for the national park to the U.S. Secretary of the Interior and lobbied the Southern Appalachia National Park Committee (SANPC) extensively; and

WHEREAS, their hiking trip to Mt. Le Conte so impressed SANPC members that the Tennessee segment of the Smokies was included as a candidate for a national park; however, legislation funding the State's purchase of land for the park stalled in the General Assembly in 1924; and

WHEREAS, Anne M. Davis then seized the reins of leadership by seeking an open seat in the State legislature to achieve this one specific goal; and

WHEREAS, Anne M. Davis was only the third woman ever elected to the Tennessee General Assembly, her election coming less than five years after the ratification of the 19th Amendment that granted the right to vote to American women; and

WHEREAS, Anne M. Davis and Knoxville Mayor Ben Morton convinced the Little River Lumber Company to sell more than 78,000 acres of land to the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, when the funding legislation encountered opposition, Anne M. Davis organized an inspection trip for the entire legislature, and her persuasive presentation, coupled with the beauty of the Smokies, effectively swayed critics, who had previously characterized the area as "stump land"; and

WHEREAS, the House of Representatives passed the legislation on April 9, 1925, and Anne M. Davis achieved her goal of establishing a national park in the Smoky Mountains; and

WHEREAS, in an appropriate tribute to Mrs. Davis and her important work on the project, Governor Austin Peay presented her with the ostrich-feathered pen that he used to sign the legislation into law; and

WHEREAS, Anne M. Davis then distinguished herself as the ultimate citizen-legislator; having achieved her goal, she did not seek reelection; and

WHEREAS, on September 2, 1940, Great Smoky Mountains National Park was formally dedicated; Anne M. Davis attended the ceremony, as did President Franklin Roosevelt; and

WHEREAS, Anne M. Davis had moved to Gatlinburg in 1931 following her husband's untimely passing; she enjoyed living close to her beloved Smoky Mountains and was active in the community with the Gatlinburg Garden Club and the League of Women Voters; and

WHEREAS, in recognition of the Davises' vital work in founding GSMNP, the National Park Service named a peak in the park in honor of Mr. Davis and a ridge in honor of Anne M. Davis; and

WHEREAS, although she passed away in 1957, Anne M. Davis lives on through her courage, vision, passion, and political expertise in the founding of Great Smoky Mountains National Park; and

WHEREAS, Anne M. Davis is a most worthy candidate to be honored in the State Capitol; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that the State Capitol Commission is requested to initiate the creation and installation of a bust bearing the likeness of the late Anne M. Davis of Knox County to honor her critical role in founding Great Smoky Mountains National Park.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the bust be installed in the alcove nearest to the Senate chambers on the second floor of the State Capitol building.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the State Capitol Commission may request the Tennessee Arts Commission to sponsor a contest, open to all interested artists, to create a bust to honor Anne M. Davis.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the State Capitol Commission and the Tennessee Arts Commission be responsible for selecting the appropriate submission for such contest and determining the final choice of artist.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that in addition to the approval of the State Capitol Commission, the installation of the bust is subject to the concurrence of the State Building Commission.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the creation and installation of the bust are subject to funds being appropriated therefor by the General Assembly.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the State Capitol Commission and the Tennessee Arts Commission are authorized to accept private funds and in-kind donations to defray the cost of the bust and related expenses.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that a certified copy of this resolution be transmitted to the Tennessee Arts Commission, the State Capitol Commission, and the State Building Commission.